

Investigating the Effect of Temperature on the Apparent Rate Constant of the Decomposition of Aqueous Hydrogen Peroxide.

January 29, 2026

IB Chemistry
Internal Assessment

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Word count: 2999/ 3000

1 Introduction

The decomposition reaction of hydrogen peroxide to form oxygen and water is a thermodynamically favourable process, but unless catalyzed, it proceeds at an extremely slow rate at room temperature.



In this investigation, potassium iodide was used as a catalyst so that the reaction (specifically, the formation of $\text{O}_{2(\text{g})}$) inside the system can occur at a measurable rate within a practical time frame. This investigation aims to explore how temperature impacts the apparent rate constant for the catalyzed decomposition reaction of aqueous hydrogen peroxide. The rate of the reaction is observed indirectly by measuring the rate of increase in gas pressure inside a sealed flask, as $\text{O}_{2(\text{g})}$ builds up.



The collision theory states that reactions can only occur when particles collide with sufficient energy and correct orientation. Increasing temperature raises the average kinetic energy and the probability of collisions with energy *equal or greater than* the activation energy (E_A). Thus, the apparent rate constant is expected to increase. This temperature dependence can be modelled by the Arrhenius equation:

$$k = A \cdot e^{-\frac{E_A}{RT}} \quad (3)$$

Where k is the rate constant, A is the frequency factor, E_A is the activation energy, R is the gas constant ($8.31 \text{ J K}^{-1} \text{ mol}^{-1}$), and T is the temperature (Kelvins). Taking the natural logarithm on both sides of the equation will yield a linear relationship:

$$\ln(K) = -\frac{E_A}{RT} + \ln(A) \quad (4)$$

Where the slope of the linear graph is $-\frac{E_A}{R}$ and the y-intercept is $\ln(A)$. As this experiment uses pressure measurements rather than concentration measurements, the ideal gas law can be used to relate pressure to the amount of oxygen produced:

$$PV = nRT \quad (5)$$

With V_{gas} constant for each trial, the equation can be re-arranged for the moles of gas:

$$n = \frac{PV}{RT} \quad (6)$$

Then, ΔP corresponds to:

$$\Delta n(\text{O}_2) = \frac{V_{\text{gas}}}{RT} \cdot \Delta P \quad (7)$$

Where T is the target temperature (K) for a specific trial, and V_{gas} is the gas volume inside the sealed flask ($V_{\text{gas}} = V_{\text{total volume}} - V_{\text{solution}}$).

* * *

As a result, the research question for this investigation is:

How does the temperature affect the apparent rate constant for the KI-catalyzed decomposition of aqueous hydrogen peroxide, determined from the rate of increase of gas pressure in a sealed flask?

* * *

Given that the rate constant of the decomposition of aqueous H_2O_2 is expected change with temperature, increasing T should increase the fraction of particles reacting with enough energy to overcome the E_A , so that a greater proportion of particles can collide, leading to a reaction. Though KI acts as a catalyst (provides an alternative pathway that has a lower E_A), the elementary steps still needs to overcome an E_A . Thus, the rate constant k should increase with temperature, according to Arrhenius's equation (approximate linear relationship of $\ln(k)$ vs. $1/T$).

2 Experimental Design

This experiment was designed to isolate the temperature of the water bath as the sole variable affecting the pressure for the KI-catalyzed decomposition reaction of aqueous H_2O_2 . Oxygen gas produced during the reaction increased the pressure inside a sealed 250 mL flask. A water bath was used to equilibrate the reaction system to within 1°C of the target temperature. The masses of KI were pre-measured and recorded before data collection, and sealed with plastic wrap and rubber band to prevent exposure to moisture.

Independent variable: Temperature of the reaction system. The H_2O_2 in the sealed flask was equilibrated to the target temperature using a water bath before the start of each trial. The temperature was monitored using a Vernier Temperature Probe.

Dependent variable: Gas pressure in the sealed flask (kPa).

Controlled variable: Initial amount of reactants, total volume of gas space in the sealed flask, environmental conditions, sampling settings, and apparatus setup were all kept constant to reduce variations in the rate.

2.1 Materials

Apparatus.

- 1000 mL beaker
- (2x) 600 mL beakers
- 250 mL flask
- 250 mL beaker
- 100 mL beaker
- Glass bowl
- Rubber stoppers
- Vernier equipments (Gas Pressure Sensor, Temperature Probe, LabQuest)
- 25 mL Pipette, suction bulb
- 10 mL graduated cylinder
- Digital balance
- Metal stick from ring stand
- Safety goggles
- Lab coat

Reagents.

- 3% hydrogen peroxide, H_2O_2 (aqueous)
- Potassium iodide, KI (solid)
- Distilled water

2.2 Procedure

2.2.1 Setup.

1. Connect the gas pressure sensor to the LabQuest and attach plastic tubing to the sensor and rubber stopper.
2. Secure the 250 mL flask on the ring stand using a ring clamp.
3. Add 25 mL of water to the 250 mL flask (to represent H_2O_2 during setup).
4. Place water bath on the hot plate and add water so that it submerges the 25 mL water line inside the flask.
5. Mark the insertion depth of the rubber stopper on the neck of the reaction flask to standardize the insertion depth.
 - This ensures that the headspace gas volume (V_{gas}) remain constant between trials.

- Before inserting the rubber stopper, add a drop of water to the stopper to improve sealing.
6. Ensure the temperature probe is not touching the bottom of the bath or the sides of the flask. Secure the temperature probe using a ring clamp.
 7. Set the LabQuest to record at *5 samples / second, 60 seconds* per trial.

2.2.2 Prepare materials.

1. Pour aqueous H_2O_2 into a clean 600 mL beaker as the master solution; can be poured back later using a funnel.
2. Weigh 0.30 g of $\text{KI}_{(\text{s})}$ into individual plastic cups, and label each cup with its corresponding temperature level and trial number.
3. Seal each cup using a piece of plastic film, and secure it with rubber band to reduce exposure to moisture from air.
4. Fill a 600 mL beaker with ice to lower the temperature of the water bath.

2.2.3 Calibration.

1. Open the valve on the rubber stopper, start recording the atmospheric pressure for 10 seconds, and record the average pressure (kPa).
2. Wash the 25 mL pipette with $\text{H}_2\text{O}_{2(\text{aq})}$ to avoid contamination.

Note: An airtight-sealing test was not conducted because the rate relies on finding ΔP over time. Pressure would be consistently lower than the actual pressure in the case of a minor leak, which does not affect the rate of change in pressure.

2.2.4 Experiment.

1. Adjust the water bath to target temperature.
2. Pipette 25 mL of H_2O_2 to a 250 mL beaker. Once the temperature of the water bath reaches within 1 °C of the target temperature, pour H_2O_2 into the reaction flask.
3. Measure 5 mL of distilled water using a 10 mL graduated cylinder, and pour into the plastic cup containing the pre-weighed KI for the trial. Swirl to dissolve the KI. Repeat twice, so that there are 10 mL of KI solution.
4. Start the data collection and collect a 3 second baseline with the flask sealed. Then, remove the rubber stopper and add $\text{KI}_{(\text{aq})}$ into the reaction flask, and seal the flask.

5. Swirl the flask for *5 seconds*, then keep the flask still for the remaining time.
6. After data collection ends, save the run, and record the LabQuest run number with the corresponding trial.
7. Dispose the solution into waste beaker, and rinse the reaction flask twice with distilled water.
8. Repeat *steps 1-7* for each trial.

2.2.5 Cleanup.

1. Disassemble the apparatus.
2. Save the file on the LabQuest.
3. Neutralize the waste solution with sodium thiosulfate, then dispose the waste solution down the drain with running water.

3 Data Collection

Level	Trial	Target / °C	Run	Hot plate / °C	Start temp / °C (± 0.5 °C)	End temp / °C (± 0.5 °C)	Mass of KI / g (± 0.01 g)
1	1	15	4	45	14.4	15.1	0.30
	2		5		15.4	16.0	0.29
	3		6		14.7	14.0	0.32
	4		7		14.9	15.3	0.32
	5		8		15.32	14.4	0.31
2	1	20	48	55	19.3	18.7	0.30
	2		9		21.4	20.5	0.28
	3		10		21.0	21.3	0.29
	4		11		19.7	19.4	0.31
	5		12		19.3	19.8	0.31
3	1	25	13	65	25.2	25.8	0.29
	2		14		25.3	25.8	0.29
	3		15		25.7	26.7	0.29
	4		16		24.7	24.6	0.28
	5		17		25.4	25.9	0.30
4	1	30	18	85	29.6	30.6	0.33
	2		19		29.1	28.5	0.30
	3		20		30.9	31.5	0.30
	4		21		30.0	30.4	0.30
	5		22		30.8	31.0	0.29
5	1	35	23	100	35.6	35.4	0.31
	2		24		35.3	35.8	0.31
	3		25		35.1	33.3	0.32
	4		26		34.7	35.3	0.31
	5		27		35.5	36.3	0.29
6	1	40	43	125	39.8	40.9	0.28
	2		44		41.3	41.1	0.28
	3		45		40.5	37.3	0.29
	4		46		40.0	41.0	0.28
	5		47		39.1	38.8	0.29
7	1	45	33	160	45.6	44.9	0.29
	2		34		44.5	43.2	0.30
	3		35		44.8	44.8	0.29
	4		36		44.5	44.7	0.29
	5		37		45.1	44.2	0.29
8	1	50	38	200	49.1	49.5	0.31
	2		39		49.8	49.0	0.28
	3		40		49.0	48.1	0.29
	4		41		49.2	49.7	0.29
	5		42		49.7	49.9	0.29

Table 1: Data recorded while conducting the experiment.

3.1 Sources of Uncertainty

To reduce random errors, 5 trials were conducted at each temperature level and averaged. Other variables, such as initial H_2O_2 concentration and volume, mass of KI, apparatus setup, and sealing method were all

kept constant across all runs so that differences in the initial pressure-increase rate can be attributed primary to temperature.

4 Data Processing

Level	Trial	Target / K	Start temp / °C (± 0.5 °C)	End temp / °C (± 0.5 °C)	Average temp / °C (± 0.5 °C)	Volume of H ₂ O ₂ / mL (± 0.06 mL)	Mass of KI / g (± 0.01 g)
1	1	288.15	14.4	15.1	14.75	25	0.30
	2		15.4	16	15.70		0.29
	3		14.7	14	14.35		0.32
	4		14.9	15.3	15.10		0.32
	5		15.32	14.4	14.86		0.31
2	1	293.15	19.3	18.7	19.00	25	0.30
	2		21.4	20.5	20.95		0.28
	3		21	21.3	21.15		0.29
	4		19.7	19.4	19.55		0.31
	5		19.3	19.8	19.55		0.31
3	1	298.15	25.2	25.8	25.50	25	0.29
	2		25.3	25.8	25.55		0.29
	3		25.7	26.7	26.20		0.29
	4		24.7	24.6	24.65		0.28
	5		25.4	25.9	25.65		0.30
4	1	303.15	29.6	30.6	30.10	25	0.33
	2		29.1	28.5	28.80		0.30
	3		30.9	31.5	31.20		0.30
	4		30	30.4	30.20		0.30
	5		30.8	31	30.90		0.29
5	1	308.15	35.6	35.4	35.50	25	0.31
	2		35.3	35.8	35.55		0.31
	3		35.1	33.3	34.20		0.32
	4		34.7	35.3	35.00		0.31
	5		35.5	36.3	35.90		0.29
6	1	313.15	39.8	40.9	40.35	25	0.28
	2		41.3	41.1	41.20		0.28
	3		40.5	37.3	38.90		0.29
	4		40	41	40.50		0.28
	5		39.1	38.8	38.95		0.29
7	1	318.15	45.6	44.9	45.25	25	0.29
	2		44.5	43.2	43.85		0.30
	3		44.8	44.8	44.80		0.29
	4		44.5	44.7	44.60		0.29
	5		45.1	44.2	44.65		0.29
8	1	323.15	49.1	49.5	49.30	25	0.31
	2		49.8	49	49.40		0.28
	3		49	48.1	48.55		0.29
	4		49.2	49.7	49.45		0.29
	5		49.7	49.9	49.80		0.29

Table 2: Raw data snapshot (full file in *appendix*).

4.1 Uncertainty Propagation

The uncertainty values for temperature and pressure were obtained from official documentations of the equipments, and the smallest scale on the digital balance was used as the uncertainty of mass: ± 0.01 g. A 25 mL volumetric pipette was used to obtain the H₂O₂ for all trials, but the exact volumes delivered were not confirmed with a graduated cylinder. Thus, the pipette's tolerance was used as the volume uncertainty: ± 0.06 mL. Time was recorded automatically by the LabQuest, so its uncertainty was assumed negligible relative to pressure variation throughout the experiment.

Tool	Uncertainty
Vernier Stainless Steel Temperature Probe	$\pm 0.1\text{ }^{\circ}\text{C}$ at $0\text{ }^{\circ}\text{C}$, $\pm 0.5\text{ }^{\circ}\text{C}$ at $100\text{ }^{\circ}\text{C}$
Vernier Gas Pressure Sensor	$\pm 4\text{ kPa}$
Digital Balance	$\pm 0.01\text{ g}$
Volumetric Pipette (Class A TD)	$\pm 0.06\text{ mL}$

Table 3: Uncertainty by tool.

However, the methodology in which the data were collected likely increased the uncertainties; for example, temperature varied during the 60 s data collection period, and the probe may not have reflected the solution temperature. Moreover, though marked, the manual insertion depth of the stopper could have introduced small variations. Thus, while linear interpolation with $\Delta T(x) = 0.20 + \frac{0.50-0.20}{100} \cdot x$ could have been used as the temperature probe's uncertainty, a conservative $\pm 0.5\text{ }^{\circ}\text{C}$ was used for all temperature measurements.

4.1.1 Uncertainty in oxygen production rate

For each calculated rate, there are random and instrumental uncertainties. Random uncertainty was propagated using the spread of the five trials' rates at each temperature level using standard deviation, and converted to uncertainty in the mean rate using the standard error of the mean ($\frac{\sigma}{\sqrt{5}}$):

$$\Delta \bar{r}_{\text{rand}} = \frac{\sigma}{\sqrt{n}} \quad (8)$$

Where σ is the standard deviation of the trials. Instrument uncertainty was propagated through the rate calculation:

$$\Delta \bar{r}_{\text{rel, inst}} = \sqrt{\left(\frac{\Delta V_{\text{gas}}}{V_{\text{gas}}}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{\Delta \bar{m}}{\bar{m}}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{\Delta T}{T}\right)^2} \quad (9)$$

$$\Delta \bar{r}_{\text{abs, inst}} = \bar{r} \cdot \Delta \bar{r}_{\text{rel, inst}} \quad (10)$$

The uncertainty of m was taken from the linear regression of the pressure-time data, and the uncertainty of V_{gas} and T were taken from *table 3*. Combined:

$$\Delta \bar{r} = \sqrt{(\Delta \bar{r}_{\text{rand}})^2 + (\Delta \bar{r}_{\text{abs, inst}})^2} \quad (11)$$

4.2 Processed Data

Temp / °C	Trial	Average temp / K (± 0.5 °C)	Mass of KI / g (± 0.01 g)	Start window / s	End window / s	O ₂ production rate / mol s ⁻¹	Avg. rate / mol s ⁻¹	Rate SD / mol s ⁻¹
15	1	287.90	0.30	37.8	60.0	$1.33 \cdot 10^{-6}$	$(1.80 \pm 0.17) \cdot 10^{-6}$	$3.52 \cdot 10^{-7}$
	2	288.85	0.29	47.4	60.0	$1.85 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	3	287.50	0.32	30.0	60.0	$2.30 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	4	288.25	0.32	32.0	60.0	$1.86 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	5	288.01	0.31	29.2	60.0	$1.66 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
20	1	292.15	0.30	31.8	60.0	$1.60 \cdot 10^{-6}$	$(1.80 \pm 0.42) \cdot 10^{-6}$	$9.44 \cdot 10^{-7}$
	2	294.10	0.28	28.0	60.0	$2.49 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	3	294.30	0.29	25.6	60.0	$2.17 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	4	292.70	0.31	30.8	60.0	$2.35 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	5	292.70	0.31	32.8	60.0	$1.90 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
25	1	298.65	0.29	29.8	60.0	$3.74 \cdot 10^{-6}$	$(3.24 \pm 0.28) \cdot 10^{-6}$	$6.09 \cdot 10^{-7}$
	2	298.70	0.29	26.6	60.0	$4.04 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	3	299.35	0.29	34.2	60.0	$3.05 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	4	297.80	0.28	24.0	60.0	$2.52 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	5	298.80	0.30	33.8	60.0	$3.01 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
30	1	303.25	0.33	10.0	60.0	$1.06 \cdot 10^{-5}$	$(7.21 \pm 1.14) \cdot 10^{-6}$	$2.55 \cdot 10^{-6}$
	2	301.95	0.30	13.4	60.0	$5.13 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	3	304.35	0.30	7.4	60.0	$9.40 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	4	303.35	0.30	17.0	60.0	$6.20 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	5	304.05	0.29	19.4	60.0	$5.07 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
35	1	308.65	0.31	7.8	60.0	$9.99 \cdot 10^{-6}$	$(8.21 \pm 0.89) \cdot 10^{-6}$	$1.98 \cdot 10^{-6}$
	2	308.70	0.31	16.8	60.0	$7.61 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	3	307.35	0.32	15.4	60.0	$8.60 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	4	308.15	0.31	11.6	60.0	$1.02 \cdot 10^{-5}$		
	5	309.05	0.29	20.6	60.0	$5.28 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
40	1	313.50	0.28	11.2	60.0	$9.54 \cdot 10^{-6}$	$(8.49 \pm 1.16) \cdot 10^{-6}$	$2.58 \cdot 10^{-6}$
	2	314.35	0.28	18.6	60.0	$7.96 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	3	312.05	0.29	16.2	60.0	$6.06 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	4	313.65	0.28	8.6	60.0	$1.27 \cdot 10^{-5}$		
	5	312.10	0.29	14.6	60.0	$6.89 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
45	1	318.40	0.29	7.0	60.0	$1.10 \cdot 10^{-5}$	$(1.23 \pm 0.26) \cdot 10^{-5}$	$5.79 \cdot 10^{-6}$
	2	317.00	0.30	16.4	60.0	$9.11 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
	3	317.95	0.29	4.6	60.0	$1.72 \cdot 10^{-5}$		
	4	317.75	0.29	8.6	60.0	$1.96 \cdot 10^{-5}$		
	5	317.80	0.29	12.4	60.0	$5.45 \cdot 10^{-6}$		
50	1	322.45	0.31	10.4	60.0	$2.99 \cdot 10^{-5}$	$(1.76 \pm 0.37) \cdot 10^{-5}$	$8.16 \cdot 10^{-6}$
	2	322.55	0.28	11.8	60.0	$1.12 \cdot 10^{-5}$		
	3	321.70	0.29	14.0	60.0	$1.15 \cdot 10^{-5}$		
	4	322.60	0.29	5.4	52.8	$2.30 \cdot 10^{-5}$		
	5	322.95	0.29	15.2	60.0	$1.35 \cdot 10^{-5}$		

Table 4: Processed data.

Note: The underlined trial was removed from calculations because the source data could not be located on the LabQuest. Run 8 from the LabQuest indicated a target temperature of 293.15K.

4.3 Example Calculation

Consider 15 °C, trial 1 as an example (marked red) in *table 4*. The headspace gas volume was calculated as the difference between the flask volume and the solution volume:

$$V_{\text{gas}} = 250 \text{ mL} - (25 \text{ mL} + 10 \text{ mL}) = 215 \text{ mL} \rightarrow 2.15 \cdot 10^{-4} \text{ m}^3 \quad (12)$$

The analysis window for the pressure-time graph was selected as the main region where pressure increased (from the start of continuous pressure increase to the end of the rise). For this trial, the selected interval was 37.8 s to 60 s:

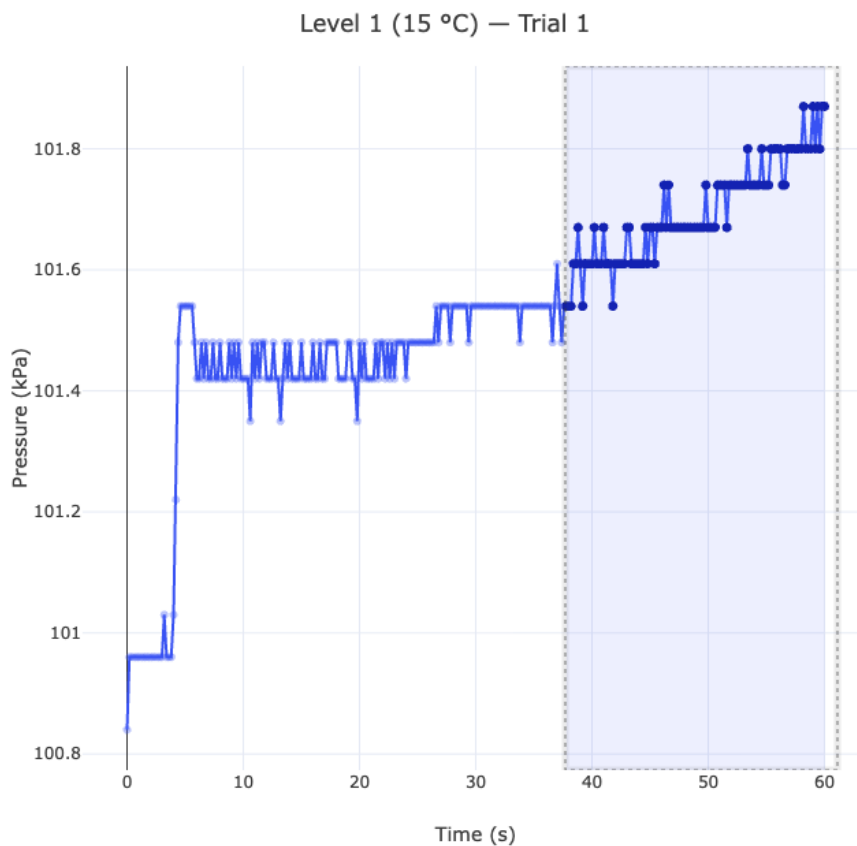


Figure 1: Pressure-time graph.

This window was chosen because the pressure before $t_{\text{start}} = 37.8 \text{ s}$ showed negligible change in pressure, while the pressure after t_{start} increased consistently, due to $\text{O}_{2(g)}$ production. A linear regression with $y = mx + b$ was then fitted to the 111 datapoints in the selected window:

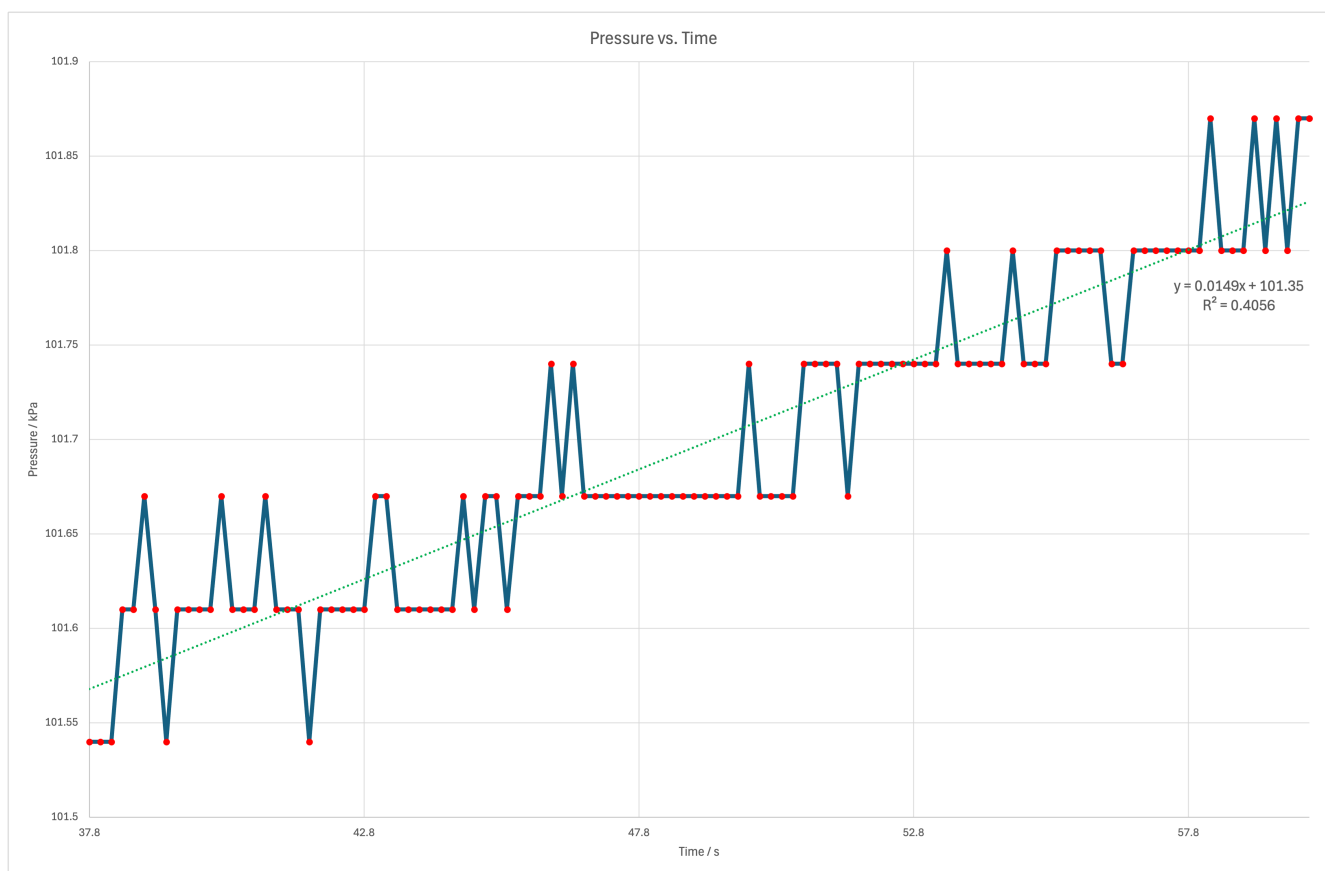


Figure 2: Analysis window.

Note that the slope m was recorded as $0.01486 \text{ kPa s}^{-1}$, which converts to 14.86 Pa s^{-1} . The rate of O_2 production was then calculated from the ideal gas relationship. For a constant headspace volume:

$$r = \frac{\Delta n(\text{O}_2)}{\Delta t} = \frac{V_{\text{gas}}}{RT} \cdot \left(\frac{\Delta P}{\Delta t} \right) = \frac{V_{\text{gas}}}{RT} \cdot m \quad (13)$$

$$r = \frac{2.15 \cdot 10^{-4} \text{ m}^3}{(8.31 \text{ J K mol}^{-1})(288.15 \text{ K})} \cdot 14.86 \text{ Pa s}^{-1} \quad (14)$$

$$r = 1.33 \cdot 10^{-6} \text{ mol s}^{-1}$$

The process above was repeated to calculate the average rate for the other 4 trials at 15°C :

$$\bar{r} = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^{n=5} r_i \quad (15)$$

$$\bar{r} = \frac{(1.33 \cdot 10^{-6}) + (1.85 \cdot 10^{-6}) + (2.30 \cdot 10^{-6}) + (1.86 \cdot 10^{-6})}{4} = 1.82 \cdot 10^{-6} \text{ mol s}^{-1} \quad (16)$$

The random uncertainty can then be calculated:

$$\sigma = \sqrt{\frac{1}{4}(-0.49 \cdot 10^{-6})^2 + (0.03 \cdot 10^{-6})^2 + (0.48 \cdot 10^{-6})^2 + (0.04 \cdot 10^{-6})^2} \quad (17)$$

$$\sigma = 3.52 \cdot 10^{-7} \text{ mol s}^{-1}$$

$$\Delta \bar{r}_{\text{rand}} = \frac{\sigma}{\sqrt{4}} = 1.65 \cdot 10^{-7} \text{ mol s}^{-1} \quad (18)$$

Calculating instrumental uncertainty:

1. Average temperature range: $0.4 \text{ }^{\circ}\text{C} \rightarrow \text{half-range} = 0.2 \text{ }^{\circ}\text{C}$

$$\Delta T = \max(0.5, 0.2) = \pm 0.5 \text{ K}$$

$$\therefore \frac{\Delta T}{T} = \frac{0.5 \text{ K}}{288.15 \text{ K}} = 0.001735 \rightarrow 0.174\% \quad (19)$$

2. Average slope uncertainty (from Microsoft Excel's Regression tool): $\pm 0.457 \text{ Pa s}^{-1}$

$$\frac{\Delta m}{m} = \frac{0.457 \text{ Pa}}{14.86 \text{ Pa}} = 0.0307 \rightarrow 3.07\% \quad (20)$$

3. Volume uncertainty: $\pm 0.06 \text{ mL}$:

$$\frac{\Delta V_{\text{gas}}}{V_{\text{gas}}} = \frac{0.06 \text{ mL}}{215 \text{ mL}} = 0.000279 \rightarrow 0.0279\% \quad (21)$$

Combined:

$$\Delta \bar{r}_{\text{rel, inst}} = \sqrt{(0.001735)^2 + (0.0307)^2 + (0.000279)^2} = 0.03075 \rightarrow 3.08\% \quad (22)$$

$$\therefore \Delta \bar{r}_{\text{abs, inst}} = \bar{r} \cdot \Delta \bar{r}_{\text{rel, inst}} = (1.82 \cdot 10^{-6}) \cdot 0.03075 = 5.60 \cdot 10^{-8} \text{ mol s}^{-1} \quad (23)$$

Final uncertainty for the average rate since they are independent uncertainties:

$$\Delta \bar{r} = \sqrt{(1.65 \cdot 10^{-7})^2 + (5.60 \cdot 10^{-8})^2} \quad (24)$$

$$\Delta \bar{r} = 1.74 \cdot 10^{-7} \text{ mol s}^{-1}$$

* * *

The approach from above was used for other temperature levels:

Temperature level / °C	Temperature level / K	Mean O ₂ production rate, $\bar{r}$ / mol s ⁻¹
15	288.15	$(1.80 \pm 0.17) \cdot 10^{-6}$
20	293.15	$(1.80 \pm 0.42) \cdot 10^{-6}$
25	298.15	$(3.24 \pm 0.28) \cdot 10^{-6}$
30	303.15	$(7.21 \pm 1.14) \cdot 10^{-6}$
35	308.15	$(8.21 \pm 0.89) \cdot 10^{-6}$
40	313.15	$(8.49 \pm 1.16) \cdot 10^{-6}$
45	318.15	$(1.23 \pm 0.26) \cdot 10^{-5}$
50	323.15	$(1.76 \pm 0.37) \cdot 10^{-5}$

Table 5: Mean oxygen production rate.

5 Data Analysis

Data from *table 4* and *table 5* were used to create an average initial rate (mol s⁻¹) vs. temperature (K) graph:

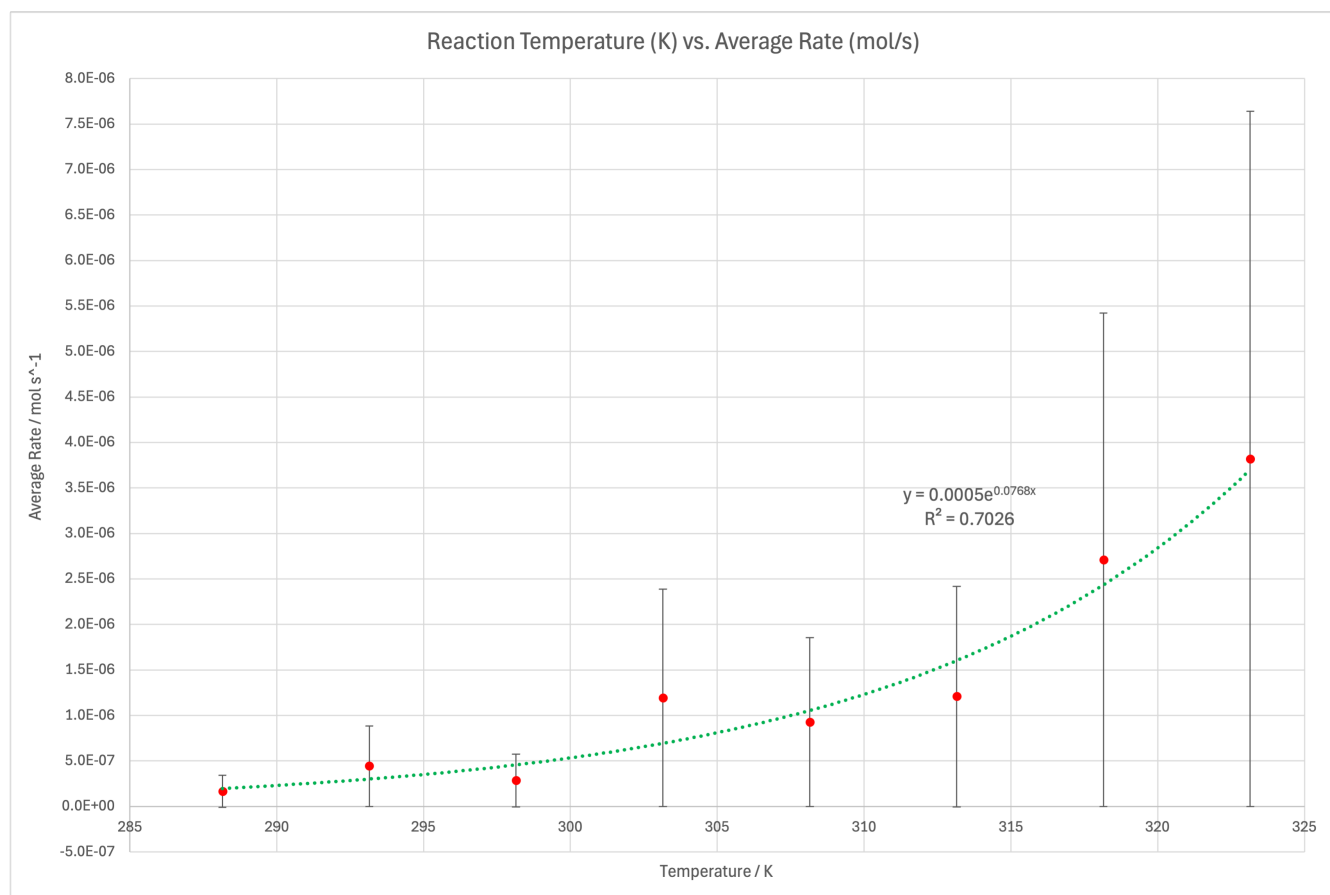


Figure 3: Graph of average rate (mol s⁻¹) vs. temperature level (K).

As shown above, there is an increasing exponential relationship between the rate of O₂ production and the temperature of the system:

$$f(x) = 0.0005e^{0.0768x} \quad (25)$$

This supports the collision theory outlined in *section 1*: higher temperature increases the frequency of collisions and the fraction of molecules with sufficient energy to overcome the E_A ; therefore, the rate of successful reactions are increased.

Given that $[\text{H}_2\text{O}_2]$ and the mass of KI were held constant (minor variations in the mass of KI), the measured rate is proportional to the rate constant by a constant scale factor difference C when initial reactants are constant:

$$r = C \cdot k \quad (26)$$

This allows r to replace k in the Arrhenius equation:

$$\ln(r) = \ln(C \cdot k) = \ln(C) + \ln(k) \quad (27)$$

Thus, plotting $\ln(r)$ against $\frac{1}{T}$ will still yields a straight line with slope $-\frac{E_A}{R}$, only shifting the intercept by $\ln(C)$:

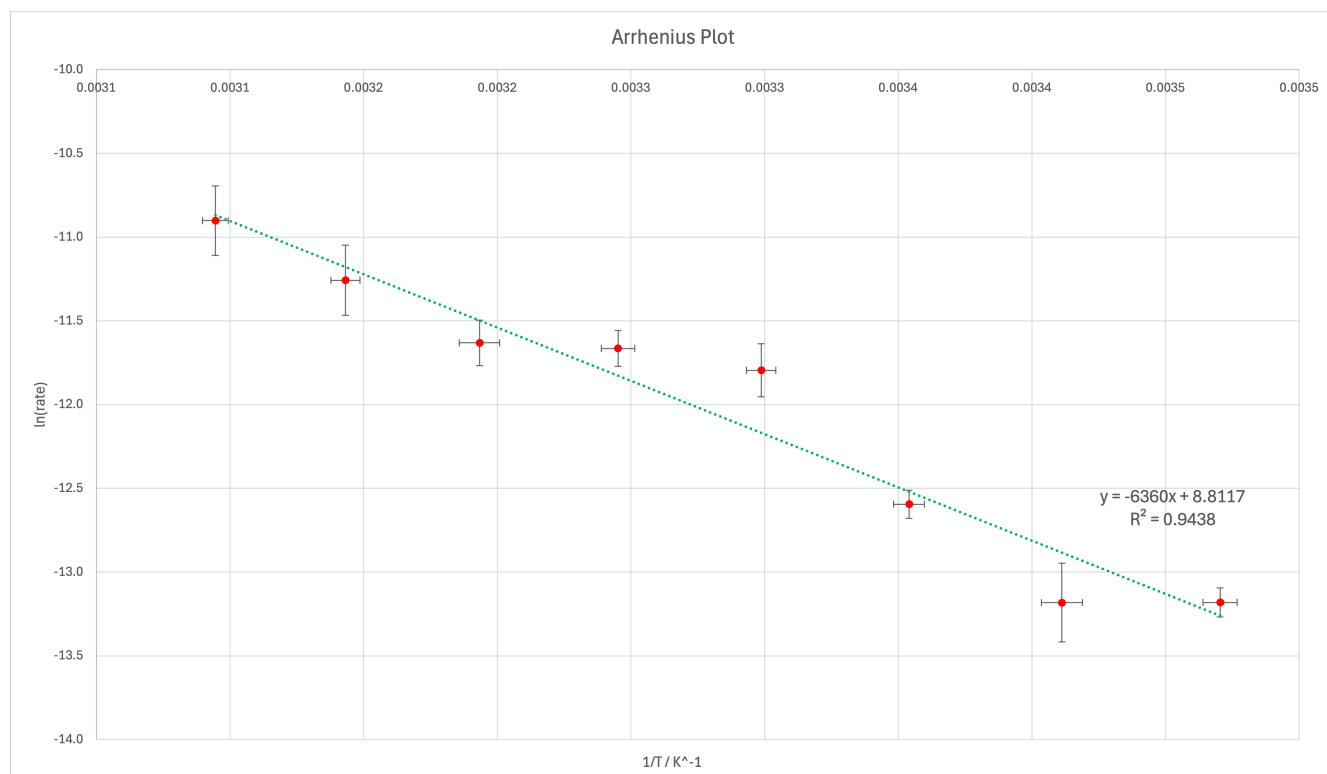


Figure 4: Graph of $\ln(\bar{r})$ vs. $\frac{1}{T}$.

The linear fit above produced a slope of -6360 K and $R^2 = 0.9438$, which indicates a strong linear relationship between $\ln(r)$ and $\frac{1}{T}$.

Recall from *equation 3* that the slope of $\ln(k)$ vs. $\frac{1}{T}$ is $-\frac{E_A}{R}$. Given that $r \propto k$, the slope is used to find the apparent E_A :

$$E_A = |-m \cdot R| = 6360 \text{ K} \cdot 8.31 \text{ J K}^{-1} \text{ mol}^{-1} = 52851.6 \text{ J mol}^{-1} \rightarrow 52.9 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1} \quad (28)$$

$$\therefore E_A = 52.9 \pm 0.6 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$$

Although the overall fit is strong, there are small deviations from the trendline that occur at, for example, the fifth datapoint (35 °C). A possible explanation for this is the slightly higher average mass of KI at that level specifically. The average mass was 0.32 g compared to an average of 0.29 or 0.30 g at other temperature levels. A slightly larger KI mass increases the amount of I^- , which can increase the O_2 production rate and $\ln(\bar{r})$ for that level.

In general, the mean O_2 production rate increased from $\bar{r} = (1.89 \pm 0.18) \cdot 10^{-6} \text{ mol s}^{-1}$ at 288.15 K (15 °C) to $\bar{r} = (1.84 \pm 0.38) \cdot 10^{-5} \text{ mol s}^{-1}$ at 323.15 K (50 °C) (*table 5*), which corresponds to an increase by a factor of x :

Calculation:

Uncertainty:

$$x = \frac{\bar{r}_{323.15 \text{ K}}}{\bar{r}_{288.15 \text{ K}}} = \frac{1.84 \cdot 10^{-5}}{1.89 \cdot 10^{-6}}$$

$$\frac{\Delta F}{F} = \frac{\Delta \bar{r}_{323.15 \text{ K}}}{\bar{r}_{323.15 \text{ K}}} + \frac{\Delta \bar{r}_{288.15 \text{ K}}}{\bar{r}_{288.15 \text{ K}}}$$

$$\frac{\Delta F}{F} = \frac{0.38}{1.84} + \frac{0.18}{1.89} = 0.302$$

$$x = 9.74$$

$$\Delta F = 0.302 \cdot 9.74 = 2.94$$

$\Downarrow$

$$\therefore x = 9.74 \pm 2.94 \quad (29)$$

This increase by almost 10 times shows that higher temperature does increase the rate constant. Because of the deviation in the fifth datapoint (explained earlier), a graph of the mass of KI vs. rate per trial was plotted to check whether small variations in the mass of KI had an effect on the reaction rate. However, no clear relationship was observed, which shows that the small variations in the mass of KI was not the primary cause of the observed temperature dependence of $\bar{r}$, and that the higher average KI mass in the 35 °C was only regional to that level.

6 Conclusion

This investigation examined how reaction temperature affects the apparent rate constant for the KI-catalyzed decomposition reaction of H_2O_2 , determined from the rate of O_2 pressure increase in a sealed flask. The processed data shows that increasing temperature increases the apparent rate constant, consistent with the Arrhenius model and collision theory. Across the experimented range, the rate increased from $\bar{r} = (1.89 \pm 0.18) \cdot 10^{-6} \text{ mol s}^{-1}$ at 288.15 K (15 °C) to $\bar{r} = (1.84 \pm 0.38) \cdot 10^{-5} \text{ mol s}^{-1}$ at 323.15 K (50 °C), corresponding to a 9.74 ± 2.94

increase in rate. The Arrhenius plot yielded an activation energy of $E_A = 52.9 \pm 0.6 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$ for the catalyzed pathway. Accepted scientific values suggest the uncatalyzed decomposition has $E_A \approx 75 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$, while the catalyzed pathway lowers it to 56 to 56.5 kJ mol^{-1} . However, the experimental value of $52.9 \pm 0.6 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$ falls 3 to 3.5 kJ mol^{-1} below the accepted range, which could be attributed to the systematic underestimation of the rate at higher temperatures: the reaction occurs at a faster rate at higher temperature levels; thus, some $\text{O}_{2(g)}$ could have escaped before the flask was fully sealed. This reduces the pressure-time slope, which compresses the range of $\ln(\bar{r})$ values, leading to a lower E_A .

Overall, this investigation confirms that increasing temperature does increase the measured rate constant for the KI-catalyzed decomposition of H_2O_2 ; the exponential relationship between temperature and rate, the almost 10x increase in rate over a 35 °C range in reaction temperature, and the linear relationship depicted in the Arrhenius plot are all consistent with the collision theory and the Arrhenius model, that KI provides an alternative reaction pathway that requires less energy.

7 Evaluation

A key strengths lies in pre-sealing each KI portion with plastic wrap and rubber band immediately after weighing. Potassium iodide is hygroscopic [1], which means that its mass would increase without proportionally increasing its moles of I^- if left exposed to air. If the pre-weighed KI portions were left unsealed, the catalyst concentration would have varied unpredictably between trials, introducing more random variation into the measured rate.

The first weakness was transferring H_2O_2 from the brown bottle into a clear beaker during each day of experiment (*section 2.2.2*). The H_2O_2 solution was stored in brown bottles to prevent decomposition triggered by UV radiation and exposure to light (not considered during experimental design). The LED lights in the laboratory emits UV radiation, and exposing the H_2O_2 to this radiation for 1-2 hours per day for five days could have gradually reduced the concentration of the stock solution. However, because the order of data collection jumped between temperature levels, due to revisiting earlier levels across different days, the slight decrease in concentration likely did not have an effect on the results. It would have caused random variation to the initial $[\text{H}_2\text{O}_2]$ across trials, which impacted the standard deviation value within each temperature level. Moreover, as visible bubbling during the experiment was not observed, its effect on the overall uncertainty is likely negligible. To eliminate this in future iterations, the H_2O_2 should be pipetted directly from the brown bottle wrapped with foil, or conducting the experiment in a dark, sealed room.

The second limitation was the use of two stock H_2O_2 solutions. The first bottle was already half-used when received, which was opened and stored for an unknown period before this experiment. H_2O_2 degrades over time even when stored in brown bottles [2], thus the older bottle is likely lower than the second bottle in concentration.

Given that the duration of which the first bottle was opened before this investigation and which trial used the first bottle is unknown, this weakness introduces random uncertainty in the initial $[\text{H}_2\text{O}_2]$. Moreover, because the rate constant $r = C \cdot k$ assumes constant initial $[\text{H}_2\text{O}_2]$, the measured rate could be driven by not only temperature, but also the initial $[\text{H}_2\text{O}_2]$. To overcome this weakness in the future, only new H_2O_2 stock solutions should be used.

The third weakness was the reaction temperature inside the flask. The solution inside the flask may not have fully equilibrated with the bath during the fitted interval due to the addition of the catalyst (dissolved in room-temperature water), which would increase the spread of data in $\bar{r}$. This can be improved by pre-equilibrating the KI solution in the same bath, and measure the in-flask temperature using a 3-hole stopper.

Finally, the last limitation lies in the Vernier Gas Pressure Sensor's uncertainty of ± 4 kPa [3]. Some trials had a ΔP below 1 kPa. For example, at 15 °C, the average ΔP over the analysis window was approximately 0.4 kPa, which is an order of magnitude below the sensor's uncertainty. Thus, the pressure readings at lower temperature levels would be indistinguishable compared to noise. However, given that linear regression over multiple datapoints averaged out most random noise, this likely had a minor impact on the results relative to other uncertainty sources. To address this in future iterations, a higher-precision pressure sensor or a differential pressure sensor should be used.

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A Appendix

A.1 Complete Raw Data

The Microsoft Excel file for the complete raw data can be found at: <https://github.com/AccessRetrieved/chemistryia/blob/d6167ade96b497181fbf9c2e57b69c0467dfe979/Data/Data.xlsx>.

A.2 Source Code

All source code and raw data are open-source, available to view on: <https://github.com/AccessRetrieved/chemistryia>.